Living With High Prices in Rural Virginia

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Java Jacks is a cafe in Tappahannock, Virginia, owned by Jeans Owens. She took over the cafe eight years ago with her husband.

Since 2022, prices have gone up a lot. Coffee at the cafe costs more than 30 percent more. A **takeout** box that once cost 12 cents now costs nearly 30 cents, and a cup with lid and straw that once cost 3 cents now costs more than 20 cents. The **power bill** went from about $450 or $500 a month to more than $1,000.

Owens keeps some meals at $10 to stay cheap. She buys milk and juice at Walmart instead of from a **supplier**, and checks three **suppliers** to pick the cheapest one.

Finding workers is her hardest problem. She helps workers find homes and drives five of them to work.

Jameka Campbell has two jobs and two children. She works at Menokin and for a food-growing group. She uses Walgreens **coupons** and tries to spend $100 a month on home supplies. "I'm not rich. I'm not poor. I'm in between," she said.

Word Treasure

supplier -- A company that sells goods to a shop.

coupons -- Small slips of paper that give you money off when you buy something.

takeout -- Food bought from a shop to eat somewhere else.

power bill -- The monthly cost of electricity for a building.

Background you need

Small cafes buy food, cups and power to serve customers.

When the prices of those things go up, the cafe must charge more or find cheaper ways to buy.

In small towns, there may be few shops and few workers, so owners must be creative.

Break it down

WHO: Jeans Owens, who owns Java Jacks cafe, and Jameka Campbell, a customer with two jobs
WHAT: They are dealing with rising prices in a small Virginia town
WHERE: Tappahannock, Virginia
WHY: Prices for coffee, cups, boxes and power have gone up a lot since 2022

Why it matters

When prices rise, families and small shops have to make careful choices about what to buy.

Test what you remember

1. Who owns Java Jacks?

(A) Her husband
(B) Jameka Campbell
(C) Walmart
(D) Jeans Owens

2. What does Owens buy at Walmart instead of from a supplier?

(A) Cups with lids and straws
(B) Milk and juice
(C) Takeout boxes
(D) Coffee

3. How much does Owens keep some meals at?

(A) More than $1,000 a month
(B) $450 or $500 a month
(C) $10
(D) $100 a month

4. What is Owens' hardest problem?

(A) Finding workers
(B) Buying milk
(C) Coffee prices
(D) The power bill

5. How many jobs does Campbell have?

(A) Two jobs
(B) Three suppliers
(C) Two children
(D) Five workers

6. What does Campbell use to save money?

(A) Walgreens coupons
(B) Walmart
(C) A food-growing group
(D) Three suppliers

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Jameka Campbell: She is neither rich nor poor, but in between.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):